

Dark Minds

An insight into the kidnappers' minds reveals shocking details

- Kidnappers have a great liking for expensive clothes, gadgets, pubs and a lifestyle that needs a ready supply of cash. What sets them apart from normal people is the extent to which they can go to fulfil these needs.
- They feel they are victims and not aggressors. Carrying a deep-rooted sense of injustice, they feel that they have not been treated well.
- The seed of psychopathy in them means they are not deterred by consequences as they are focused on gains, which leads to high rate of recidivism.
- Some families try emotional blackmail by telling the kidnappers that all the money is theirs, or even getting them married to stop them to repeat the act again. But this is not effective as they feel they are justified in what they did.
- It is a well considered move. But since they are not professionals, they leave many loose ends in their plots that leads to, more often than not, foiling their bid. Under tremendous stress from the time they kidnap, the kidnappers reach their snapping point quickly and sometimes end up killing the hostage impulsively.
- Unlike professionals, they can't handle being exposed. Being an insider, they keep themselves aware of the moves of the family.
- Most of these cases involve children from urban rich families, the business class, rural or semi-urban rich who acquired huge wealth in quick time by selling land or property.
- Many of them enter into a partnership for the act with outsiders. In such cases, outsiders were found to take the lead in motivating insiders to help carry out the crime.

Source: Swanchetan society of mental health, Delhi

in 2009 (up from 22 in 2008), the kidnappers were known to the victims in 32 of the cases. On February 22, a two-day long kidnapping drama was foiled by the Gurgaon Police when Shrawan—in his early 20s—kidnapped his 10-year-old cousin Vikas Gupta with the help of a married couple. Son of a bakery owner in Patel Nagar, Delhi, Gupta was lured by the kidnappers by saying that they'll take him for *My Name is Khan*. Interestingly, the identity of the kidnappers was ascertained by the CCTV

ANISHA SHINDE



THANE KIDNAPPING

Sunil Yadav, 15

His parents wanted him to become a doctor or an engineer, but he had no interest in both. So to avoid the exams, Yadav staged his own kidnap and demanded Rs 10 lakh as ransom from his parents. Missing from Thane, he was finally held in Allahabad after 10 days when he called his parents after he ran out of money.

footage of the multiplex where the kidnappers took him.

Mitra says his experience has been that in cases where the victim is not harmed and the kidnapper is a family member, the police encourage the matter to be settled within the family, so no case is registered. The police do suggest professional counselling to help instil a fear of the law. Sessions with kidnappers indicate that they perceive themselves as victims and not aggressors. Kidnapping is a well considered act, and not impulsive, fuelled by the fact that the

kidnappers have inside knowledge of movements, routines, amount of money that can be demanded and other intimate and significant details. Like the case of Thane boy Sunil Yadav, 15, a Class XII student, who staged his own kidnap and demanded Rs 10 lakh as ransom from his parents. Remaining elusive for 10 days, he was finally held in Allahabad after he called his parents when he ran out of money on February 2. The reason for this extreme step was given by his father, Ganesh, who runs a retail shop, "We wanted him to become a doctor or an engineer, but he had no interest in both. He did all this to escape his examination."

Things can also go terribly wrong as the kidnappers are all first-timers who panic easily. Like in Lucknow in September last year, Saket, in his early 20s, abducted his 18-year-old cousin from her house. He told the police that he meant to demand Rs 10 lakh from the family but ended up killing his cousin in panic. DCP (South Delhi) HGS Dhaliwal says, "There is too much of pressure on kidnappers to meet consumerist needs that they do not have means to fulfil and many a time family tensions cause it to take an ugly turn." As happened in Rajkot a couple of years ago, when a four-year-old child Tahir Pathan was kidnapped and killed by his cousin Saiyeed, 16, because he reportedly hated Karim, Tahir's father, for being harsh and rude to him. To Saiyeed, this act was revenge. In most cases, however, it is the lure of money.

Visvanathan says that this is a manifestation of tremendous violence within the extended families, primarily who have newly acquired wealth. "The family inheritance of wealth is unjust and patriarchal," he says. To Mitra, the boys who indulge in these acts have an element of criminality, as they are not fearful of the consequences and are focused on the benefits they will get out of it. More so when it involves someone they know, crime is increasingly becoming a family affair. ■